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Skitch Henderson

Skitch Henderson was born Lyle Russell Cedric Henderson on January 27, 1918 in Birmingham, England. His family immigrated to the Midwest where he began his career in music playing piano in roadhouses with territory bands. His accomplishments since then are legendary. Skitch has been a pianist and musical director with many of America's leading artists including Bing Crosby, Kate Smith and Frank Sinatra. NBC and CBS employed his talents for many years and he is often remembered for his association with The Tonight Show from 1962-67. He is the founder of the New York Pops Orchestra and a frequent guest conductor with symphony orchestras around the world. His wide interests include aviation, automobile racing and cooking, and he spends his precious free time at The Silo with his equally talented wife Ruth.

Skitch was interviewed at his home in New Milford, Connecticut on October 31, 1998, by Monk Rowe, Director of the Fillius Jazz Archive.

MR: My name is Monk Rowe and we are filming today for the Hamilton College Jazz Archive. And it's quite an honor to be here at The Silo outside New Milford, Connecticut with one of the most distinguished members of America's musical community.

SH: Confused member, yeah, confused member.

MR: Skitch Henderson. I'm kind of in awe just reading through your little book here of how many things you've done in your life, so I was going to congratulate you on one or two of them but I think I'll just congratulate you on your career.

SH: Well it's a business of luck you know. I started as a rehearsal pianist in films and World War II came and I flew the great war as we say, and I came back and went to MGM. The grass was growing and the cottage, the bungalow as we called them where I used to rehearse these great stars, the hinges were broken. It looked like the great Midwest during the dust bowl. And I thought whatever happened you know.

MR: You kind of got in on the ground floor again?

SH: So then I drifted into radio. And then I saw radio disappear. I've been through all these train wrecks.

MR: And you've come out on the other side.

SH: And then somehow, well I was working at NBC with Sinatra actually. We were doing Lucky Strike and a Vice President of NBC walked up one day and said, "What are you going to do?" It's a great straight line, isn't it? And I said, "Well I'll probably go back to Hollywood and try to make a living." I didn't know what I was going to do. Then he said, "Why don't you stay here" — I love this line — he said "we're going to do television." I love that line. And I stayed there and stumbled into television.

MR: What brought your family to the United States? You were a teenager?

SH: Yes I was a teenager, I was in England, but my mother died when I was very young and my father sent me to live with his sister who lived in Minnesota. And I was obedient at the beginning and then the minute that she turned her back I ran away.

MR: No kidding?

SH: Yeah. I played with territory bands, pretended to learn how to improvise, and began to see what the truth in music was.

MR: The truth in music. I was curious you probably had classical lessons.

SH: I was a total square, still am in many facets, yeah.

MR: When you got your first inkling that there was more beyond the notes on the page, when was that, in the territory bands?

SH: Yeah, well even before that. I played in a saloon — excuse me, night club you're supposed to say I suppose but to me, I don't know, it was probably a partial brothel. They were building the Fort Peck Dam in Montana, and I played at a place, I can see its vision in my eyes, the Red Rooster was the name of it. That's where the "rowdies" as they called them, that were building the dam came at night to revel with the ladies who were in attendance. And there was a gentleman there, an Indian, his name was Art Hopple, he played tenor saxophone. And I thought he was wonderful. I mean I didn't know but it was incredible to me that they could say a song or something and he'd play it. That was unheard of to me. And he was wonderful. He had great patience, and said you know, "You must learn" you know "that everything isn't on the page and start experimenting." It was the beginning of another education.

MR: What was the repertory at that time. Swing tunes?

SH: Well I don't think we — only maybe "Honeysuckle Rose" was supposed to swing. "Lady Be Good" I think, that's about as contemporary as I got you know. And then there were, I'm ashamed to say I don't remember them now, but there were pop songs so-called. But that's when I first learned what standards were, you know Victor Young, "Sweet Sue," songs like that I began to learn. And then I began to learn what time meant, which is my — if you've been around my spa here, I collect clocks. I live in a time factory. That was really a tremendous beginning, which I didn't realize at the time.

MR: I guess in an atmosphere like a roadhouse or night club, you learned the importance of playing requests?

SH: Immediately. Immediately. He also was wonderful because he taught me to have a glass with color in your glass and he didn't want me ever to drink and he was an alcoholic. He didn't want me to start drinking. I was a teenager. And there was many lessons that were very meaningful in my life. Art Hopple. I loved him. I tried desperately in the years when I was, during the NBC years when "The Tonight Show" was really heavy and we had

such viewership all over, I tried through every station owner in Montana and North Dakota, South Dakota, to find him, and I never found him again.

MR: I understand that you played some for silent movies too, or of making them not silent, in the movie houses.

SH: Yeah. Well my mother did that, that's where I started. She was a church organist in Birmingham, England, and then at night, a couple of nights a week, I believe it was Friday and Saturday, she used to go to the local cinema house and play an old beat up upright piano, and watch the screen. That fascinated me because I was already very — she had the hammer on me to study, and I went down to the London Conservatory when I was very young. I stayed away from home as we say.

MR: On those movies, did they give you a score of musical cues?

SH: Suggestions, yes.

MR: But it was partly up to you?

SH: It was really, you know when Ormandy — God rest his soul — when Eugene Ormandy was alive, he and I used to talk a lot about that, because he conducted at the Capitol Theater in New York, and he once mentioned something to me how he said, in Hungarian he wouldn't say tampered, he acquired melodic content that didn't belong in the film. And he said what the things that they sent for the theater orchestras to play, an orangutan could conduct. You know he said there was no interest in the music. So he began really to investigate music structure in the classical school even though he had had the schooling as a player. And he said that really was the motivation for his conducting career. Isn't that amazing? The years before the Philadelphia Orchestra. He was a wonderful man. He was strange, warm. For ten years he said, "You conduct my orchestra" but I never did. When he passed away I was invited to conduct his orchestra. So typical of our profession.

MR: You've had some amazing friends and associates over the years, including I read that you studied with Schoenberg?

SH: Schoenberg — after the war Arnold Schoenberg was in Hollywood. He was somewhat of a refugee, not politically but musically. You know he was lost in Germany and Austria. It was a bad time to go back. And he had friends. There was a man by the name of Morris Stoloff who was music director at Columbia Pictures. And he announced that he and his wife were kind of the home in Hollywood of Stravinsky, Mr. Rachmaninoff, Horowitz, who was on his sabbatical — he was practicing but not playing for the public, and Ernst Toch and Schoenberg, people like that, the Stoloff house was a gathering place. And for some reason I played piano on a date for Morris, something that Ernst Toch had written that was incredibly difficult technically according to the house pianist, and I of course waltzed through it because I had no brains just courage. So I became a member of a very kind of funny, a lonesome, elite society. And then when Mr. Schoenberg started teaching

at UCLA he was very unhappy because most of the kids slept, they just went there for a credit of some kind, you know they'd nod through class. And I had the audacity once to say, I was then working in Metro, that I'd like really to take a score and show it to him. And that opened a dam because he then told me that he was a radio arranger in Radio Berlin at the same time that Dmitri Shostakovich was a radio arranger in Moscow, and that the arrangement of "Tea for Two" which has become famous, of Shostakovich, Mr. Schoenberg said, "I did fifty of those, none of them ever became famous." He was a strange, strange man. I was frightened to death of him. He wore — like I'm dressed today — in California he wore black and he didn't like sunlight. So strange to be a refugee in California.

MR: Did you start arranging out of a kind of an innate interest in it or because it looked like something that you needed to do?

SH: No. We called it "brute force school." I started fixing things, as a rehearsal pianist, and then I think as you hear sounds and if you have fat ears and listen I think that's the best teacher, in my opinion.

MR: I know Manny Albam said the same thing.

SH: Really?

MR: Yes. He absorbed everything around him from all the different kinds of music he listened to.

SH: Well you know I lived in Hollywood, in fact I saw — I was conducting in the south last night and I saw a friend, a gentleman that I hadn't seen for a long time who was kind of an assistant director for Warner Brothers in the golden days. And we started talking about Max Steiner and Ray Heindorf and all of these people that I lived with every day, and never really knew how important they were and what a stroke they put on not only my life but the life of America. You know, Alfred Newman at Fox. And I worked for — my first boss at MGM was a man by the name of Herbert Stothart who did all the Nelson Eddy musicals so I learned all of that repertoire. Nelson Eddy and Jeannette MacDonald. That was my first training, but I read everything, no improvisation.

MR: Didn't you make your way to Hollywood with a chance encounter with Judy Garland?

SH: Yeah. Yeah there was a troupe on the road. I was playing with this rinky-dink band in Colorado at a hotel which is now torn down mercifully, in Denver. And it sounds like a cheap film plot, but they came through, Judy and Mickey were starting to do the Andy Hardy series at MGM, it was the late '30s. And MGM sent them out on what we call a "trip to huckster everything." And Mickey would do half of his father's act. His father was a burlesque comic, Joe Ewell. And Mickey would do the clean part of his father's act, and then Judy would sing a couple of songs and they'd show the film. It's strange. And their second trip out was Denver, where their pianist became ill. I mean this could

never happen but it does. And a gentleman by the name of Frank Perquette was the tour manager for MGM so-called. And he called desperately to find somebody. He called the hotel. They lived in the hotel where I was playing with this so-called orchestra. And I think he called the hotel manager or something and asked if I could be sent down to help them out. And the hotel manager was wonderful, he said that I read music. And I thought that that was the most wonderful recommendation. And a day later here I am on the road for MGM.

MR: And you gave a twelve hour notice to the rinky-dink orchestra.

SH: Oh I doubt if I gave twelve hours. They were so in awe that I got this job, I think they harbored some respect for me. Three saxophones, two brass, a girl singer, the leader played violin, horrible, and his brother played drums. I can still visage the orchestra. And a bass player who constantly played out of tune.

MR: Wow you've come a long way.

SH: Not necessarily. We still have problems today.

MR: Just more players now. Can you recall what you would have made per night at that time with this particular orchestra?

SH: I think we made about $35 to $40 a week salary as I recall, but that, when we played in the hotel we got what you would call military subsistence. I think we ate, for a minimum price, one grand meal a day and that's really what you lived on 'cause you could have breakfast at that time for a quarter or thirty-five cents. But I think 25 or 35 dollars was it, because I think they paid me 50 when I went on the road, and paid my expenses, you know and I lived like a gentleman so-called.

MR: And that was considered territory bands?

SH: Territory bands, yes.

MR: You might travel a three or four hundred mile radius.

SH: Yeah, that would be it, yeah. I played with three or four of those bands. Unbelievable. They were all bad, but this was a great learning process. In fact I played with a band, his name was Buddy Fisher, another — he imitated Ben Burney. I don't know how he ever came about that but he talked and he spoke lyrics and thought he was such a star in front of the band. And we played Kansas City at the Muhlbach Hotel and I went down to the very famous street and met a guy by the name of Bill Basie, who had a seven piece band in the Reno Club. And I remember that I don't remember who it was in the band, but somebody wanted to play something in the key of G, which was unheard of that you'd play sharps, because they played E flat, B flat, F, C, that was it. Maybe three flats, yeah E flat. Maybe A flat, or as a big chord, a D flat. But something like that. But anyway, I could play in the key of G and that astounded Basie, that I could read in sharp keys. And then for the rest of my life, and Ruth, my wife and I loved Bill very much, he called me

"F Sharp Henderson." That was my name, the rest of my life, wherever I would see him. We did a concert once with the San Antonio Symphony, which was one of the greatest memories of my life, believe it or not with Ella and she was on — Ella, Bill Basie's band, and quite a decent period with the San Antonio orchestra. It was one of the greatest nights, music nights, I just sat there like you're living in Valhalla, but nobody came. I couldn't believe it. It was a benefit but they put up a sign and said here they are, but we had a very small house as they say so the promoter was less than friendly with us. But what a musical night we had.

MR: Too bad it didn't get recorded, right?

SH: Oh that would have been so wonderful.

MR: F Sharp Henderson.

SH: F Sharp Henderson, but only from Bill.

MR: I heard his key was F or —

SH: Always.

MR: What is it, "One O'clock Jump" is like in D flat or something. I always wondered why — that's pushing it. The process of learning to do scoring for film, how did you learn to do that, with a click track and all that kind of thing?

SH: I think again by brute force. If you sit there — I sat in the orchestra and watched guys die in front of producers. Good composers. One: Aaron Copland — die in front of these, forgive me, idiot producers who want everything to sound like Wagner or something. I mean that's the only name they knew you know. They didn't know Mahler or Bruckner then. Everything was Vaagner—Vaagner—Vaagner. And I think sitting behind the piano bench or sitting behind the piano looking and watching was almost the best teacher. Also, we lived in a very cruel society at that time because what I observed I suffered under when I tried to step forward. There wasn't any subtlety. If things didn't work it didn't work and you were out the door. I mean I watched men like Victor Young, I'll never forget, we played a main title for Cecil B. DeMille and Victor was a magnificent orchestrator and I mean the Paramount Orchestra was first class. And there were two pianos, I was on the date. And we played this main title we just absolutely were in awe of his skill of putting it together. And Cecil B. came in in his pates and his entourage following him and sat down. Now we sit in this grim, soundproof studio. We play this magnificent main title and there's quietude because you never spoke until the boss spoke you know. And Mr. DeMille said something like, "That isn't my music, is it? Is that the music you wrote? Is that the music for this film?" He said, "Well if it is I don't hear any melody." So there was kind of a deathly silence, DeMille and his entourage left, and he said, "I'll be back in a week or so, but I want to hear some melody." So a week later he came back and Victor as a jazztet scored the melody in unison for the whole orchestra.

But he didn't get the joke, he didn't get the joke, so it was no joke. But I thought of living through those things, and it was a very tough, very tough business.

MR: You had your turn under the gun eventually on the podium.

SH: Yeah, well I'll tell you, you know how I started? The conductor wouldn't show up. It was always in a panic. Often the conductor was the orchestrator or composer or arranger, dishwasher, and may times they'd be late on the date. So you know everybody'd be looking at their watch at whatever the call was, so they'd say, "Kid why don't you stand up" — because as a piano, I never had, maybe a belltone or something. "Kid, why don't you stand up and give us some time." That's really how I started.

MR: Give us some time.

SH: Time. And then Victor Young said there was a wonderful gentlemen by the name of Albert Coates who was a conductor in the period of Thomas Beecham in England, and he was driven out of England by Beecham with his wealth. And he formed an orchestra for the Czar before the royal family in Russia was done away with. And there are still records with him, Coates, and he was a great, great conductor. And Victor Young said, "If you had any brains you'd go take some conducting lessons right now. Maybe you won't learn anything but just do it." And that's really how, then I began to see how serious it was and how tough it was. Because most of the guys in Hollywood were leaders, you know we called leaders. You know they'd drop their arm and hope you'd play, because everything ran from the click track, so the musicians were built-in, you could leave them alone they probably could play the cue better than anybody else.

MR: Those clicks, did they work on the quarter note? Were you hearing the quarter note or were your hearing something different?

SH: No you'd generally hear a time factor leading to like if it was, let's say you had a [scats] you'd hear maybe three clicks ahead of it [scats] and you'd go [scats]. It would be set up ahead of time. It was a conducting cue is really what it was. It would drive you crazy. At the end of the day you hated everything.

MR: Wow. It must have been very stressful.

SH: Sometimes — I was trying to think of one conductor I worked for — he won the academy award once too, he did westerns, big westerns though, for Selznik. He used a big orchestra and scored to the screen, which was unheard of at that time, I mean this was, because this involved another union and eight more men in the studio. Nothing changes.

MR: Yeah. I was just going ask about that.

SH: Dmitri Tiomkin.

MR: Oh, yeah, he did some John Wayne films too.

SH: Dmitri Tiomkin, at the close of his life, I was just starting to have an idea of doing concerts, when Lenny Bernstein had that New York Phil. He talked to me once about, they couldn't play his music. He had written "West Side Story" and the New York Philharmonic never had played anything with syncopation and time, never. So he said, "Why don't you start with members of — do a spring season — you know do some concerts. It will help them understand what I'm about, and play whatever music you want. And I did two weeks at Carnegie, which was a super train wreck, absolute disaster. We outnumbered the house every night. But at that time Tiomkin came in and did a film score at Carnegie with something like — I'll be kind, I think it was like a hundred and five men. And they played pianissimo. And I loved it because Dmitri said, "Well that's the only way it works. You only can get a big orchestra to play softly and to keep the sound." I think of that when I'm on the stage sometimes trying to get a pianissimo in the orchestra.

MR: Was it hard to get, in those situations, the orchestra to swing?

SH: Oh, there's no such word. I was called when Joey Bushkin had problems, I was called to substitute in the Tommy Dorsey Orchestra and that was, I mean I just couldn't believe what that was. That was the orchestra with Frank and the Pipers and Buddy Rich, Chuck, all the guys. It was the most incredible — I wouldn't have called it — I mean there's a difference the word dance band and orchestra, but this was ostensibly a dance band because that's where they were playing. But the first night I went there I was horrified that I was so unfit. I didn't know whether you — do you play time? What do you do? So I just tried desperately to stay out of the way all night. Then about 11:30 at night, Tommy came to me and said, "I have a piece of sheet music here on a piece called "Sleepy Lagoon" and Tommy loved to play in sharp keys, he loved that." And the orchestra didn't play it, you know normally you don't score in sharp keys. And I played it, and it was in the key of A I think I played an arpeggio and Buddy Rich hit a big rim shot and said "waterfall has arrived." And that was, I was sent out to pasture. But I played that, I played "Sleepy Lagoon" while the dancers stood and looked at us, like a concert, just the two of us. And the orchestra thought I was from Mars, but I began to have tremendous respect for quote dance bands, which I mean I had a band for two years after the war, I never could get it going. And of course the business was over then too.

MR: The swing business.

SH: Well that world, you couldn't afford to take twenty gypsies on the road, especially if you had a couple of alcoholics and had to bail out of the hotel every third day.

MR: What's your take on why that era ended so quickly?

SH: I don't know, because none of us knew it was ending, at least I didn't. I wasn't intelligent enough to know it was happening. I think the amplifier of course was one of the death

nails, I feel. I mean it's funny, I lived and worked in New York at NBC and I watched this, because when I shed the band I went back to NBC with Sinatra and was doing the Lucky Strike Show and it was the beginning of — what would you say, rock and — contemporary, I don't know what term you use. And I sat there at 30 Rockefeller Plaza and didn't have the — I'd go listen but I couldn't understand it. And I watched Bebop go through. I watched all of that go through. It was so hard for me to — I must say it was hard for me to assimilate it. And maybe that was the problem. Maybe all the men, because there weren't many women, all the men that lived through that era, maybe they were just so stunned by the change. And didn't time have a lot to do with it, that's again the time factory. I can't complain because I watched my kids, I tried to watch or listen through their eyes. Everything was time. Rock was time. Even The Beatles was time.

MR: Yeah. In straight eighth notes.

SH: Yeah. Something happened. And that Renaissance to almost the style of Mozart you know, it was a very strange Renaissance.

MR: Yeah. Can we talk about your love of flying for a minute? You ended up going back?

SH: I flew in the RAF yeah, during the war, yeah. At the beginning of it I flew for almost two years.

MR: Now were you an American citizen?

SH: I wasn't yet, no.

MR: So that's why you could have.

SH: I was on the cusp, no I had no choice. And I guess I'm a total aviation buff or whatever those words are. I mean I sold my airplane last year because I had a rather adventuresome acquisition of the land properties at Westchester Airport one night when it was rain, freezing snow, so I called my good friend and said I think I'd better hang it up. It's funny I just saw, in the city where I was conducting I just saw a reunion of a photo recon squadron that flew in Britain and also flew in Africa. I didn't know them at that time but we got to talking and found out that we'd been side by side in the desert running from Rommel, and we were all — they flew P-38s and that airplane was a disaster in the African desert because of the inline engine and the sand. They couldn't keep it running.

MR: What were your flying assignments?

SH: I flew Hurricanes. A cloth airplane with a metal stabilizer, a metal wingtip, not much protection. We used to beg and borrow every piece of metal that we could put under our derrieres. I was only shot down once, I was in pretty good shape.

MR: That's amazing. And then you flew some for the United States, too.

SH: Then I came, I did a show, I went back to England on leave because I'd heard so much about the Miller band. And I flew back to London – I got leave and flew to London to hear it, and I arrived there before the band had arrived yet. There were rumors naturally.

And I ran into Crosby, Bing Crosby, who said, "I'm doing a benefit tonight" well not a benefit, but, "I'm doing a USO show at this club tonight, why don't you come and play a couple of tunes with me?" And I was a Flying Sergeant, and in RAF you didn't go to quarters where the officers — you just didn't step across that line. And I told this to Bing and he said "if you don't go I don't go, it's very simple, so come and have dinner afterwards." And he talked to some gruffy Admiral of the Royal Navy and another man by the name of Andy Cannon who ran the Air Transport Command that took supplies back and forth across the Atlantic for the American Air Corps at that time. And I couldn't believe Bing. He said, "I don't want this kid to get hurt," when he found out where I was flying, it was very dangerous. And I went back to my squadron in Africa, and my backman was a Scotsman who said, and I can't repeat what he said, but with a large expletive, he said, "You really did it this time, you're either out or something is wonderful for you, I don't know. We're ordered to send you right back." And I went to London and put on the other wing with the other wing, and flew the rest of the war as a Yank.

MR: And did you get to hear the Miller orchestra?

SH: Yeah.

MR: Good you heard it then.

SH: I recently conducted the New Haven Symphony in Woolsey Hall, and that was where that orchestra was born, the military orchestra. When he broke up his dance band, New Haven was the headquarters. That's where they brought all of these musicians. Isn't that wonderful? Ray McKinley, everybody, all of them came there. Zeke Zarchy, oh, wonderful, wonderful players, friends of mine, were all in that. I thought of conducting that orchestra on this stage, and I looked at those long hairs in the symphony and I tried to say to them, "Do you have any idea what went on on this stage?"

MR: You decided to do television.

SH: I didn't decide, I had no — it was a job.

MR: It was a job.

SH: Well then I was music director at the network. I became music director, so I became the head psychiatrist for an institution of 185 problem children, between my organist who played the soap operas— And when I started we still had the symphony of course, with Mr. Toscanini.

MR: And this was what year?

SH: '50, 1950, '52, '51, '52. And that again was luck because Mr. Toscanini didn't want to do summer concerts. He wanted to go back to Italy. So he gave me an orchestra. And he told me never to play French music, and to learn the Italian overtures, which I very carefully

did learn and that was of great value. And then I was there for of course the sad dismissal of the orchestra.

MR: Which, you attribute that to the bean counters?

SH: Oh greed, greed. When Mr. Sarnoff was alive and in power he dreamt of having the same thing you would have in Europe, you know. I fortunately through the years have worked with Munich with the Rundfunk in Munich and Stuttgart and most of the good German orchestras, the Neudautsche in Hamburg. I worked with wonderful orchestras there. And of course the BBC through the years, but that too is going by the wayside. The second orchestra in the BBC is gone now.

MR: The musicians over the years that you've worked with in TV and in the studio have contained a lot of our best jazz musicians.

SH: Well that was the home factory. Because as the band business, as we talked about, began to dissipate, a lot of these men had no place to go except to play in theaters and at that time it was sin to play a pit job, it really was strange—

MR: No kidding.

SH: —how the philosophy changes. Now it's the elite job in New York. But at that time, they really didn't want a staff job either. It was strange. They didn't know where to go or what to do. So I brought men like, well I could start with Doc Carl Severinsen. I took him from Charlie Barnet's band, and Clark Terry from the Ellington band, Tommy Newsom was with the Navy band in Washington, Hymie Schertzer had been with the Goodman band, I mean I could go through the whole, Bobby Haggart of course of fame, the best bass player I've ever known in my life, and Bob Rosengarden, who pretends that he never played with Henry Bussey but he did.

MR: I'll tell him that. You actually referred to him as the Chairman of the Board of the Time Factory.

SH: I always felt that yes.

MR: Him and Bucky Pizzarelli.

SH: And Bucky of course I knew from the Vaughan Monroe Orchestra. So it wasn't me, I had a commitment to change the style of the orchestra and to do that, you know you have to start from scratch and I was so fortunate to have these type of players who still had enthusiasm for playing. And then one of my jobs was to do the service shows, The Today Show and The Tonight Show. I mean I did specials, but The Tonight Show, I was stuck in the pit for a long time. And then having Steve Allen, who loved this and was learning to play piano. And then I must say when Carson came aboard, he didn't want me there. He wanted somebody else, because I was the house man. So he looked upon me as a sort of spy you know, naturally. That's the psychology of our business. And for a couple of years it was this smiling beautifully on camera and total silence off.

MR: No kidding.

SH: Then it came round. And I feel, and this has nothing to do with me it has to do with Torrie Zito and a lot of the guys that wrote for me so much — Dick Lee played bass trombone and still writes for me for the symphony. That was an unbelievable band, because they were all superstars in their own right and they were horrible to get along with because at the time they didn't speak to each other. You know, I mean everybody had their own two-person clique.

MR: The guys in the orchestra?

SH: Yeah. And I had about seven trumpet players, Jimmy Maxwell was another.

MR: I wanted to show you a photo here that Bob Rosengarden gave us. It's got quite a decent trumpet section there.

SH: Yeah, that's Doc and Clark and Snooky, yeah, Bob and—

MR: Marian McPartland there. The bari player?

SH: Yeah the baritone player. He's in Hollywood now. This was a funny night with Goodman. I asked Goodman, I think I must have asked him for two or three years to come and do the show, and he never would do it. Benny was Benny. "No, Pops, forget it, Pops. I'm not going to come down and have to rehearse." So at last I saw him one day and I said, "Benny, I'm going to give you a gift." I said, "I'm going to get all of Fletcher's old charts and they have been blown up just a bit, there are five saxophones instead of four, and I want you to just — it would be good for you, and I want you to do it for the guys in the band. Because you'll never have an aggravation or an aggregation like this again." Anyway he did the show. I asked him who he wanted to play piano, and it's interesting that he called Marian McPartland, as opposed to Teddy Wilson, which fascinated me. Anyway it was a hell of a night. Now I'm playing, I'm conducting — two years pass, and I'm conducting in Brisbane, Australia. Now I'm not in Omaha, I'm in Brisbane. And the phone rings and it's Benny. I mean I hear this voice. "Hey Pops, I left my braces in Sidney, do you have any spare braces?" You know, suspenders. So I said, "Yeah I guess so." And then that night after that concert he and I sat and talked in this smelly gymnasium where they played, and it kind of broke my heart because I said, we had a confession period to each other. He was talking to me about his unhappiness that he hadn't, even though he was a very successful player and guest, he had no placement with a group because nobody would work for him, he was so mean, let's face it. Bobby Rosengarden, I think Bobby refused the calls, everybody did. They gave up at last. So I in this strange night in Australia said, "Benny, I have very few things that ever made me smile on The Tonight Show because there was always rankling from upstairs about the clients," and I said, "the band took care of itself and I just had to work out the schedule." But I said, "The night you came on and played it really thrilled me to hear that, that you

could have that kind of virtuosity in every chair." I mean there wasn't a guy there that hadn't paid their dues a hundred times over. And there was dead silence and he looks at me and said, "Yeah, Pops, but it didn't swing." And then he launched into a tirade. He had just toured with a British band of five brass, four saxophones and three rhythm, like the old, old Benny, 1936 Benny Goodman Band. And that's what he was happy with. I'll never forget that. "Yeah, Pops, but it didn't swing." That, Bucky and I, Bucky Pizzarelli and I talk about. Because Bucky was good to the end. He'd go to the house in Connecticut and play with Benny, just the two of them, just to make him play. But it was strange that he had that.

MR: He wasn't even happy with perfection.

SH: Yeah. And he was such a perfectionist.

MR: Wow.

SH: "Yeah, Pops, but it didn't swing." That was, for me, almost like a curtain coming down in Benny's life with me. And I told the guys. Of course they thought what else do you expect him to say?

MR: Right. They would have been shocked if he said it swung. You must have had circumstances on The Tonight Show where questionable talent as far as singers and so forth.

SH: Oh horrendous. We didn't rehearse. We showed up. We had a call, I think we started taping at that time around seven o'clock in the evening. We tried to get going about then. And we had a five o'clock call. And a five o'clock call generally meant that I would check if everybody was going to show up. Because Doc was starting to spread his wares with high school — you know he'd go to, what do you call it—

MR: Clinics and so forth.

SH: Clinics. He was suddenly discovering that world. And Rosengarden was always recording someplace, he was always twenty minutes late, and Haggart didn't want to be there in the first place, and Tony Mottola and Bucky, all of those guys, they rotated the schedule unto themselves, but half the time they'd forget who was there. But it was probably the best, in my opinion, of this period. If you're going to say — well it was probably the best organization. And it was their organization. Nobody talked. If you talked to any of the guys they'll say, "I didn't talk, I just looked." Mottola was the looker. Haggart, when Haggart said, "I've got to get out of here" a couple of nights "You can't keep me here five nights, I won't play five nights, I'm out of here." So it's hard to find a bass player that plays time. There are a lot of wonderful bass players, but who plays time? So I brought in a young man, we played one tune, and Mottola sat in front of him, a totally quiet Italian, and we finished this tune, and he was a product of the boppers, the bop school, so he played eight thousand notes. Never played anything on the beat, never,

God forbid, played arpeggios all the time. And we finished this tune and there was silence in 6B, and it was like a Kafka movie where all the — well I think it was thirty seconds, but all this time Mottola took a cloth and cleaned off first his guitar and then put it on the rack and slowly turned around and looked at him. That's all he did. And we knew it was over, he was gone the next night. But I had many adventures like that. Many. I had Al Klink in that band, who came from the Miller band. He was the, when you talk about the Miller band, there was one reason that that band worked with the octave of the clarinet and the tenor, and in tune. Imitators, in my opinion, Walt Levinsky and I talk about this all the time, the imitators never can understand, if they do they just don't play enough one nighters to get it together, you know. But the real genius of the Miller band was that octave of the tenor and the clarinet. And Al Klink played so magnificently. And Tommy Newsom were our chief tenor players. What a luxury. I'm so lucky to have had that.

MR: When you listen to — or I don't know if you do — but when you hear the bands that are playing for the late night shows now—

SH: I can't stand it. I have to confess. I shouldn't say that. They are doing what they should be doing. But you know they are in essence what we were, the vaudeville bands. We were a vaudeville band when The Prince, as we called Carson, or Steve Allen, when it wasn't going, we had all kinds of schtick that we would do, we were like a traveling circus. That's when Doc started doing his accent. I mean everything like that. We had bits that we would do to crank up the studio, you know, it was a fascinating time to watch so it was really vaudeville. And that's what I feel these small combos are. They're loud. That's the only thing that bothers me is the huge volume that they put out.

MR: Someone floored me once recently, they said whistle any of the theme songs from the late night shows these days.

SH: I can't.

MR: You witnessed the integration of the studio bands.

SH: Yeah.

MR: When did that start, in the early '60s was it?

SH: Well it started about the time that I brought Clark in, because they used to spit on me when I first became music director. We had no men of color in the orchestra. Two Italians, they said they were colored. But seriously, and during the very — when the movement was very strong they really were rough on me at NBC and I tried to explain to them that it took time and that I had to have people who would fit. Clark Terry was — Clark and Snooky were the greatest disciples that ever came along. But Clark and Doc didn't speak to each other. It was interesting. I mean they played, if they were together they played back — they always looked the other way, never get audio. Doc said Clark

— what was it — Doc said Clark played out of tune and Clark said Doc had no tune. So they had some colloquial like that. But that was the beginning of the so-called integration. It's strange how we talk about it now that it's gone by the board. It was very rough for me at one time though. And I didn't know any better.

MR: You just wanted to get the best players?

SH: I just wanted players, that's all, and I took whoever came along. I mean I would get messages from the guys. I mean we really ran our own little police state, it was wonderful. And even though I had a big orchestra, that was a different troup, it was a troup of about 20 to 25 players who did The Tonight unit. And that was a mafia unto itself, and nobody, you couldn't get in that door, it was pretty hard to get in.

MR: It's almost like the players coveted the gig, at the same time—

SH: Resented it.

MR: Resented it?

SH: Yeah. It gave them visage they had never had, and that visual thing brought them to every conductor. Morton Gould used to call me and say, "I'm recording next week I need Doc, I need Bobby — fix Tuesday and Wednesday so I can have them."

MR: Oh — let them off, huh?

SH: That went on all the time. They became, and are and deservedly so, all of them became kind of peripheral stars.

MR: The pops orchestra thing, did you spot a need for that?

SH: No. I didn't know what else to do. There was no more studio. I didn't fit anyplace. I'm not much of a rocker, and I guess then what I began with was my, I don't know, stuck in my craw, something so-called I mean — forgive me — legitimate schooling, which is still very important. There was a man who ran Carnegie Hall called Sy Rosen. And after I had my catastrophe when Lenny Bernstein had the Philharmonic and I had this two week train wreck of all time, I recorded with that orchestra. They're still buried in a vault someplace — with the Philharmonic. Made lots of sides, never to be released, mercifully I suppose. Sy subsequently became manager of the Pittsburgh Symphony and then the Philadelphia Orchestra. And at both places after work when we'd be at the local watering hole, he would say, "Why don't you try it again sometime?" And my wife, God bless her, registered the title New York Pops. She was so angry that I had stumbled, that she didn't want the Philharmonic to take the name, see? She said I'll get even. So she registered that. And we just sat there and then one morning I got a call that the Boston Pops, Arthur had played what he called his beer date, every April, for something like 26 years he had played the same Wednesday night at Carnegie Hall. Never an ad, always sold out. Typical Boston Pops program with Arthur. Then John Williams comes aboard, but he comes aboard with this colossal public relations marketing team who made him the God

of music. Well you know you can't come to — you can but you can't — you can't come to New York that way, you know what I'm saying? And I think he thought that he'd come in there with the Boston Pops and he would just absolutely turn everything over. Well the press just crucified him, as they have all of us at one time or another. And he, well I think within the next couple of days, I don't remember exactly, but he told Boston he'd never play, take the date off the schedule. And the day that call came to Carnegie, Ruth and I we have a little flat in New York, he called Ruth and myself and said, "Maybe that's the omen, maybe you should try it again."

MR: Who called you?

SH: Sy Rosen. This same man, Sy Rosen. He now had gone from the Pittsburgh Symphony to the Philadelphia Orchestra where he was manager, to now running Carnegie Hall. And isn't that something? In that call he gave me a fairly stiff price what his estimate, what it would cost, and we did, as it were, a preview. We did one single concert. It began to rain at three o'clock in the afternoon, and it rained I think until four o'clock the next morning. It was like the South Pacific. But we didn't have an empty seat. And we lost a good bit of change but it was the start of it, that's seventeen years ago now. So strange at this time in my life to have such a golden wand of players, but it is a legitimate orchestra. It doesn't, I mean when we start playing four to the bar I just want to run out of the house. I try to get a small group maybe interspersed from time to time.

MR: I don't mean to keep bringing up Manny again, but he talked about that too, about trying to write for strings and make them swing, and he basically said don't bother.

SH: No. You're wasting your time. I had a wonderful experience — Bucky found, Bucky Pizzarelli found a gentleman who is now 96 years old or something, a black violinist from the south, I think he lived in Carolina or someplace. And Paul Whiteman had heard him play, and Paul Whiteman was a genius businessman. And he heard him play and he called in one of his myriad arrangers who sat at his elbow, and they wrote arrangements on standards for four violins, traps, utility percussion, bass — we can't tell, it's probably one or two guitars, and piano. Wonderful, wonderful arrangements. And Bucky, the gentleman, when Bucky was on the road with Stephane Grappelli, he brought this case of music to him, so Bucky brought it back to me and we looked at it and I said, "You know when I have you or maybe when I have some time players with this orchestra, I'm going to take the two concertmasters and two principals from the second stand, let's read them through" you know because we thought we'd discovered something that would be wonderful. They couldn't play it. Could not play it. I mean they could play the notes, but it was just an absolute colossal disaster. It made me think how creative, I don't know, the word jazz doesn't apply to me, I'm such a jazz fan, but how wonderfully, the virtuosity of great jazz players. Because that's what they were, all of them.

MR: How much time do you get to create an album with the New York Pops in the studio?

SH: I don't know. Show up and get it over with. I just recorded with a lady from Japan for EMI. I'd never met her, the music didn't arrive until that morning.

MR: Same day?

SH: She sang in as we say the native language. So I spent the time looking at her diaphragm, feeling that if I watched her diaphragm I could understand what she was going about. And we did something like four sides in three hours with a big orchestra. It was unbelievable. She's going to be with me in Tokyo this year. She did this as a preview. But there is no time. Time is gone. It's gone. That's a part of technology or part of greed. I don't know what it is. I began in the record business when we got thirty-five dollars for a date. I made a record with Sinatra, the first record he made I played piano, "Night and Day" and "The Night We Called it a Day," Axel Stordahl made the arrangements. Eleven or twelve men in the orchestra. And thirty-five dollars, and you took out, I don't know, there was Social Security, yeah it had started, so I think you ended up with like twenty-eight dollars, this was a big day.

MR: Did you have to do that, isn't there a six month period when you come to New York for the union, to get in the union?

SH: No, I had to do it in Hollywood though.

MR: Oh, yeah.

SH: No New York, see I came to New York, NBC signed — when I came to New York I started doing, with strength, the Lucky Strike Show in New York as a conductor so they couldn't say anything about that. And I guess, I don't know how the devil I got into it, I guess the New York Local just gave up and probably made me a member you know, because I still belonged to 47 and 10 and the Guild in England. But in Hollywood, when I went to Hollywood, it was almost a year. Six months was the law, but it was almost a year before I got anything, and I mean I played rehearsal piano for everybody, but oh, never in studio orchestras.

MR: Do you get residuals from your work over the years in Hollywood?

SH: Very little. Very, very little. It's better the last, what, fifteen years I suppose. But the golden years, gone.

MR: It's all gone, huh?

SH: Yeah, there's nothing. Well it's our own fault too. Or I don't know whether it's anybody's fault. Sometimes it bothers me, especially when you're looking for something, like when I did my 80th birthday gala, there were snippets of film that I wanted to use that were meaningful to me, but some guy in Pretoria, Ohio owns, you know, he's bought the rights, and he wants ten thousand dollars, I mean for a minute and a half of film. Maybe we're all wrong.

MR: Someone's getting it.

SH: Yeah.

MR: The years — you did some tours with Sinatra, on the road?

SH: Yes. Yeah, we closed all the theaters. We were the end of vaudeville. The act was, the company was the Will Maston trio, which was the father and uncle and the center of the trio was Sam Davis Junior, he was ten years old, and they were a dance trio. That's where he came from. He was our opening act, and then we'd always have an animal act because Sinatra and I both loved animal acts. And they we'd play, we closed all the great houses: Chicago, Detroit, Philadelphia, Washington, all the big eastern houses. That was the last hurrah of vaudeville.

MR: What year?

SH: I don't know when would that have been? It probably must have been in the early 50s, maybe late 40s. I don't remember exactly. No, it must have been the late 40s, because television was already coming around the corner strong in the beginning of the 50s.

MR: Technology has had such a big effect on live music over the years, from I guess when the talkies came in there went the pit orchestras for the silent movies.

SH: And of course in film, about twenty years ago went the big orchestras. That's why you have to thank the John Williams' and the Elmer Bernsteins and the people who absolutely said this can not be. And it's fascinating to me now that I go to the cinema and I hear an orchestra many, many times. Because my ears perceive that groan of that synth — well of course nobody uses, they say, that's not chic to say synthesizer anymore. You know it's electrical reproduction of some kind. You don't say synthesizer.

MR: I can imagine you've had to play some questionable pianos dating back to your Montana days, and I think it's interesting that now you have this association with Steinway.

SH: Well I always was the seventh son in the Steinway family. The B that's behind me here was my NBC piano for years. And 199, the concert grand, which is adjacent, in the hierarchy of the days of Graffman, Catcham, Horowitz — oh I could name, I'll leave the most important — Rubenstein, 199 was the most sought after concert grand for some strange reason. So much of it was a pain in the neck to the Steinway factory because Horowitz would take it to Omaha and then he'd suddenly forget to ship it back, he wanted to take it to Lincoln or someplace the next night or the next week. And they got so disgusted, that John Steinway said, "We're going to take it out of inventory." And when Ruth found that out she went quietly to him and said, "Can I buy it, we won't tell anybody." And it sits here. And it's in pretty good shape. When at first my son was young, twelve, ten, twelve years old or something here at the farm once, and I used to have it in a studio. My wife has removed the studio, it's her office now. But I had it in the studio over here. And I was always asking Horowitz, who was my neighbor, to come

over and play because I wanted to know where the piano should sit. We lived in barns you know. Where should the piano sit? But he never came. He always said, "I come Skitch, ya, I come." Never came. One day we're having dinner or lunch with some friends, and my son comes running up to where we were and he said, "There's an old man playing your piano." And it was Volodya, playing Chopin, for the kids. And they sat and listened. And that was 199. He was happy to have the reunion.

MR: I'm so pleased you've been able to find us a little time in your schedule. I just wanted to ask you about this whole wonderful home you have here, and The Silo. It started as a small idea and kind of grew into your cooking school?

SH: Well that's not me that's my wife.

MR: That's your wife Ruth?

SH: She carries the brain factory. I carry the travel factory. No I was in the racecar business at one time and one of our dear friends was a Grand Prix driver, as many of them, was killed. And his wife and Ruth started a little shop here. And then Louise decided this wasn't a life for her so Ruth took it over and that was 25 years ago. And of course it's grown like topsy, it's fantastic what she's done, and all the superstars of the cooking world come here to teach, which to me is the greatest accolade, because that's for her really that they come. You know, Pepin, everybody comes here. And we live in a barn. My tractors were here when I moved here. This was the tractor barn.

MR: You have an affinity for tractors also.

SH: Yeah. Old tractors.

MR: We saw like a steam driven tractor.

SH: Yeah, the steamer is sitting out here, yeah, I have boiler problems, so I'll get that fixed. But I have to get off the road to do it.

MR: Yeah. Don't fly it, okay. Keep it on the ground. Is there something in your career that you haven't done yet that you'd like to?

SH: It's funny, that's a very good question because sometimes Ruth and I talk about that, if there's — you know sometimes you get so involved in what you do for a living that you forget everything else. And I really can honestly say, because I've always been a nervous wreck all my life. Tomorrow is Armageddon. Because this is that kind of a business. I mean we used to say at NBC there's a twelve year old walking behind you, he wants your job. I'm serious. And I think I've always lived in that factory of insecurity. And I think for the first time, because I have a wonderful orchestra at Carnegie Hall, and I get to guest conduct some wonderful orchestras, and I think for the first time I have almost, I should never say it, but I almost have a comfort. And I think it's too late for me to try anything else. I'm so bloody lucky that I've stumbled through all these transitions of music, I mean starting with territory bands or starting in a roadhouse, and being able to

climb a very long hill. And I was never a very good politician. You know everybody talks about, oh politics, everything is politics. I don't believe that's true. I think it's association, friendship, and as Crosby used to say, be prepared. And that's what I feel. If you get a chance to make a step of any kind, be prepared. You know what you're doing before you get there. And the guys that I watched in the early days of music at Metro, the czars, I mean they didn't make a statement if they didn't know what they were saying.

MR: Some of the major czars as you say, were actually pretty hip musically, weren't they? In the early days?

SH: Oh surely. Well a lot of them came from, some of them like Johnny Green they came from dance band experience. A lot of them did. A lot of the orchestrators. Where are you going to learn to write like that? You start with the dance band, like the great American composer William Schuman, began his life writing for dance bands. I couldn't believe that. He told me he had a dance band in New York, for years he said, that's why he said he was so glad to get away from saxophones. And I to this day am not a saxophone man either, except Newsom.

MR: Newsom. All right.

SH: Yeah. Tommy Newsom. He could play anything anytime for me. He's so wonderful.

MR: Wow. Where are you off to — tomorrow you're back to New York?

SH: Back to New York. I have a heavy week in New York and then I go down to, I have an orchestra in Tampa — I don't have it, I'm music director of a series in Tampa which, it's called something very original, the Florida Orchestra, but I've been there about thirteen years and we play Tampa, St. Petersburg and Clearwater and the cities on the west coast. It's quite a good orchestra. And I'm looking forward to the next program because we're doing a program based on the music of South and Central America and we may even, I say the word hesitantly, we may try to experiment with them playing some Bossa Nova.

MR: Can I guess that Bob Rosengarden will be there to help with that?

SH: Always. Yes. He's the time salesman.

MR: Well this has really been an extreme pleasure for me.

SH: Well it's a pleasure for me, thank you, I'm glad that I got here continuing the commute, what is it, an 1800 mile commute, that's a pretty good commute. One nighters used to be a hundred miles, but now—

MR: In a cold bus.

SH: Well this was a miserable airplane. So thank you.

MR: Well congratulations on your 80th birthday and your 40 years with Ruth, is that right?

SH: Yeah.

MR: And everything else that goes with it.

SH: Thank you.

MR: All right. Thanks a lot.